

Faust and the Birth of a Research Agenda

ENCOUNTERING FAUST

Based on a real person, Dr. Faustus, who lived in Europe in the early sixteenth century, several artistic works combined to build the legend of Faust and the *Faustian Bargain*. Accordingly, Faust came to be known as a man who sought forbidden knowledge and made a bargain with the Devil. In exchange for his immortal soul, Faust would be given the power to know. The two best-known and most acclaimed renditions of the Faust tale were created by English playwright Christopher Marlowe and German poet Johann Wolfgang von Goethe. Marlowe dramatized the irrevocable nature of a pact signed in blood with the Devil, the frivolous and unsatisfying end to which the knowledge was put, and, finally, the passionate and desperate damnation that lay at the end of Faust's search for "illegitimate power through learning."¹ Goethe in his mid-nineteenth-century *geist* modified the bargain and made it contingent on Faust's having a moment of contentment. Goethe allowed the angels to rescue Faust because his search and aspiration never ceased. Faust triumphed in the end. Although these two literary works differ in their emphasis and form, they both kept the Faustian Bargain as the crux of their artistic vision.

Surprisingly, Goethe's *Faust* was also translated, along with other important Western works, into Chinese, and therefore it served as an inspiration for a New Cultural Movement in China during the early twentieth century.² My late mother remembered seeing the book as a middle-school girl in the 1930s in her school's library in a rural Chinese town where only a few privileged children could attend school. She did dare to open this book with a strange title, but her desire to read further was put to rest for good because she could understand nothing.

Later, in the 1970s, the first group of Chinese students emerging from the farm labor of Mao Zedong's reeducation program,³ after ten years of closed schools and condemnation of education, entered college. We woke up from a deep slumber and were shocked to find that China had been left behind. "Economically destitute and culturally barren" (一窮二白) was the general sentiment. The indescribable sorrow that befell everyone was that the Mainland Chinese thought that they had it right, fighting a noble cause to correct a great social wrong, pursuing relentlessly equality, equity, and emancipation from their millennia-long cultural yoke toward some undefined ultimate bliss. But we were wrong (even evil in the world's eye); what was even harder to bear was that we were more pathetic than Don Quixote tilting at windmills mistaken for giants. A hitherto unknown sense of collective shame and anger toward our leadership erupted. A quick reaction was, rightfully, to restore education. All of a sudden, schools were reopened and knowledge, particularly scientific knowledge, prized.

Backed up ten years, millions of students waiting their turn for higher education, still dispersed in the countryside, were urged to hurry to review their book knowledge in order to partake in the first college entrance exam. Many simply gave up because after high school they had trashed or burned their books to display their anti-bourgeoisie resolution, or else they packed their books away, never to touch them again. But many rose to the occasion and gave it their best shot. I was lucky to pass the exam, and the reported ratio of college admissions was 4.7 percent from those who took the exam.⁴ Although we were not given much choice of schools and subjects of study (there were few to begin with), most students desired schools and programs that had a reputation of Western disciplines such as natural sciences and technology. However, the most desired subject of study was, perhaps, European languages, with English ranking at the top and French and German next. These languages were especially sought by those who felt not less desirous, but less prepared, to pursue scientific studies. At that time, it was true that few Chinese were fluent in these languages. The Chinese government and people alike had known, since the end of the imperial system at the turn of the twentieth century, that for them to have any chance of making it in the modern world, they had to increase their population's proficiency in Western languages. After all, foreign language is, as Marx asserted, a tool in human struggle – a slogan that every schoolchild could recite, if not comprehend. Studying foreign (really Western) languages became an ever-greater aspiration even when Marx's glow grew dimmer.

The idea that one could be lifted out of the ruins of a collapsed state and learn new things from the advanced human world was analogous to a

drowning person holding onto a thread of air. Not only did those who passed the exam harbor the utmost hopes for their own lives, but their government also regarded them as its only hope and epoch-defining fresh blood. These students went to college with all tuition and all study-related fees waived. Moreover, they were not expected to engage in energy-draining work-study to earn extra money. In other words, they were made worry-free, all for one purpose: to devote their time and energy to study, to master what China had lamentably neglected for ten years.

Such was the ethos under which I began my college career. We were an elite group, but not by birth or socioeconomic status; there was no birth class or difference in socioeconomic status. We passed the exam and were chosen; that was the commonality. Before the exam, all exam takers had to declare three schools and three subjects for each school as their preferences. I named English as my first choice of study, followed by French and German, for all three schools. I was admitted into my second-choice college, one of the best schools for foreign languages in the country. The college admissions officer later told me that the reason he placed only me in the German group from all the province's applicants was that I was the only student qualifying for English but also willing to study German. Without any regret and with only gratitude, I welcomed the placement and plunged into my German studies.

To maximize these students' success, the Chinese government contracted with West Germany to send teachers from gymnasiums and universities. As a result, my four years of college were mostly taught, quite unusually, by West German instructors with a curriculum much tuned to their pedagogical theory and design. Although we also had Chinese professors who taught some German classes and other subjects such as history, Chinese literature, economics, and English, German teachers were mostly responsible for what we studied. As far as I can tell, students of my class had a good taste of liberal arts education from the West, understandably with a German bent (the same was true in the French and English departments based on their respective instructors from abroad).

Students exhibited high energy and motivation for learning by any standard. We all got up early in the morning and read our texts aloud. All tried to memorize their vocabulary sheets and related texts. All went to the library to study, and all read into the night in their tent-like mosquito nets until lights went out. No one missed a class unless one was too ill or had an emergency. We did sports and extracurricular activities, but the sight of everyone holding a book in their hand reading, and of a very crowded library, was a daily occurrence. My husband, European American

by origin, taught at the same college and to this date attests that he had never – and has never since – seen such a sight on any of the campuses of some twelve American colleges and universities where he has taught. He still could not believe the level of these Chinese students' dedication to their learning.

German is not an easy language for any non-Germanic Westerner, but it was notoriously harder for the Chinese, whose native language does not have conjugations for anything, let alone the three articles, four cases, and endless combinatorial variations. But we absorbed all those mechanical difficulties of the language. We mastered the pronunciation, sentences, comprehension, grammar, even some medieval words and usages. We studied German history and read Goethe, Schiller, Heinrich Heine, Georg Büchner, Gerhart Hauptmann, Thomas Mann, Robert Musil, Franz Kafka, Bertolt Brecht, and the writers after World War II. We listened to Mozart, Beethoven, Schubert, Schumann, Mahler, even Wagner. I loved learning about this important European culture. As this learning deepened, Chinese culture became more and more a distant and vanishing memory. Anything Chinese was scorned. We did not even speak much Chinese on campus because we were busy practicing our German. We also frequently dismissed our German teachers' curiosity about Chinese culture and told them that it was not worth their while because it was the Chinese culture (mistakenly, in hindsight) that brought our country to ashes.

But then came Goethe's *Faust*, a monument of German literature. By then, the knowledge-thirsty students had gained some perspective and had cooled down from the embracing zeal they had cultivated in the revolutionary time. Print materials that revealed unheard-of things were "smuggled in" from Hong Kong, and some classmate even got connected to a Buddhist monk who sent her hand-printed material about Buddhism. We read these things with a flashlight in bed. This exposure and gradual change prepared the students for what might be called a questioning spell. We began questioning everything, not necessarily in open forums but certainly in chats with peers, leisurely strolls, and romantic interactions. We contemplated our existence, our *sein*, our experiences, our society, German culture and people, America, life, death, love, virtually every subject. It was like a mini-renaissance where free spirits roamed outside classrooms. I remember a poem that I wrote in Chinese to share with my peers:

Progress and Regress

The train is dashing through the Yellow Plateau, and I am counting the
tombs of ancient emperors....

Who says that tombs
Symbolize only death?
I'd say they symbolize immortality and eternity
Who says that the running train
Is progress in our time?
I'd say it's blind curiosity
Like children
Who have to tear into pieces the mushroom
To see what's hidden inside
People on the train are fooled by it
Modernization is not visible in the far end
But tombs are visible right here with us
As if they are reminding us
To contrast, to reason, and to reflect
The train lures us
To follow, to dash, and to blunder

However, despite this vibrant learning, we remained quite “uninterested” in our own culture.

Faust, especially the first parts where the Faustian Bargain took place, was read slowly and discussed line by line. Although the poetic form was no longer daunting, we had difficulty with all the religious tradition and allegories. I remember thinking to myself, tossing ideas to my friends, and hearing their echoes back: Why does Faust have to lose his soul, his life, for wanting to know more? Ignorance was precisely what the Chinese suffered. What's wrong with Faust wanting to be more knowledgeable and wanting to have full human experience? Why did Goethe, the literary giant, write an epic in such a way that seeking knowledge is like committing a crime somehow? Even more, aren't we this guy? Here we are devoting ourselves with all our might and passion, seeking knowledge, resembling in some way Faust's spirit, if not his full scope. We were puzzled. But neither my peers nor I actually raised these questions to our German teacher in fear that we might make fools of ourselves, questioning Goethe. At least for me, I could not abandon these questions until I found their satisfactory answers. But before that happened, I had to come to America to endure more bewilderment and soul searching.

SHOCK IN AMERICA

A few years after college, I gave up my position teaching German and immigrated to America. My first desire was to make myself useful to my

newly married life: finding a job. But my English was abysmally poor. This self-assessment was actually not an incidence of the well-known “Asian” self-effacement. My English was abysmal; I had spent all my time perfecting my German. I simply did not spend enough time mastering English. Truth be told, I did not even like English very much because it did not have the complicated articles and cases, or the elegance of the logical combinations of sentence variations. I managed to learn to read and write English at some grade level. But speaking and listening proved to be out of reach. Coming to America was not planned, but I fell in love with a European American. Although I lucked out with this marriage, *Gott sei Dank*, at the time I experienced a profound displacement when I found myself in the United States instead of Germany.

I registered, with my husband’s help, as a substitute teacher for German in Burlington, Vermont, where I first landed after immigration. The reason was simple: That was the only thing I could do, short of being a Chinese restaurant kitchen aide. This job did not require a teacher’s certificate, and for a while I thought that I could at least teach the fun German language to American students.

Unfortunately, my first teaching assignment at the local high school was English rather than German, which, as confessed previously, I could hardly speak, let alone teach. I had to admit it to the caller just in case she made a mistake. But despite my honesty and insistence that I lacked any qualification for teaching English, I was told that the school needed me, and I had to be there. So I went, in a cold sweat, too scared to face something like an English equivalent of *Faust* – Shakespeare or anything vaguely literary! I wanted to disappear into the ground.

Someone ushered me into the office, trying to calm me down, saying that it would be an easy job, and that the only thing I needed to do was to follow the lesson plan made by the called-in-sick teacher and “to keep the kids out of trouble.” “What trouble?” I said to myself, gazing around. I had never seen, not even in my dreams, such a school, with all the brightly lit classrooms, hallways, and all the books in the library. The students were undoubtedly well nourished and well clothed, projecting more self-confidence and happiness than I or any student I had seen back home. This is a learning paradise! What trouble could there be for such blessed lives?

To my shock, those students did not seem to care about maintaining a good learning environment: They chatted freely and giggled and threw things at each other as if I, the teacher, did not exist. What struck me most was that they were not the least bit interested in learning the content of the already minimal English tasks. But my surprise did not lead me to blame

the students. Instead, I blamed myself and my poor English. It was then that I vowed to learn English well enough not to let this disappointing situation happen again in my substitute classroom.

As my English and self-confidence improved, sadly, I saw a recurrent, actually more severe, scenario in Pennsylvania. I became, on a *blitz* track, a supervisor for student teaching at the University of Pittsburgh only a year later. I thought that it was strange to bestow such responsibility on me given how little I knew about American education. It was even more bizarre for me to supervise student teachers while struggling through my own student teaching (in German finally) at a high school in a remote town where I provided the only ethnic diversity. Perhaps this was the university's way to kill two birds with one stone. In any event, I was forced to function like a two-headed creature, or else a split personality, while still struggling to improve my English.

My regular visits to five schools across four districts and my daily work in the classroom gave me a pretty good chance to encounter students' lack of interest in learning. This time I could not hold myself responsible because I mostly did not teach. Where I actually taught, I did succeed in boosting their morale for learning from moment to moment, but it often felt like a drop in the ocean of disinterest. In fact, it was this very difficulty that discouraged me once and for all from pursuing my certificate to teach high school in America. Nevertheless, in hindsight, I must say that these Pennsylvanian students were angels. No one really had any "trouble," at least not the type I was aware of: dropping out, drugs, teenage pregnancy, and violence, barring perhaps smoking and other petty offenses. By and large, these students showed up at school on time, remained through the day, and did their assigned work. Not everyone made the best effort, the kind I would have liked to see – certainly not the one that would resemble the by-now already archaic fantasy in my head, the effort worthy of the Faustian spirit. But compared to what I later saw in urban places, these students were any teacher's dream.

Massachusetts students were not better, not even in the supposedly better towns, away from the really troubled inner city. The same lack of enthusiasm in learning continued to shock me as I again endeavored to work more in schools. Of course, the education reform, along with the weekly news reports, drumming up the meager academic performance of American students gave me a clear sense that what I observed was not an isolated phenomenon. My perplexity deepened; the idea of the richest nation on earth inhabited by so many students not wanting to learn really threw me for a loop.

FISH DISCOVERING WATER

At the University of Pittsburgh, I took several courses in educational psychology and child development as required for my teacher certification. The most thrilling course ever was on how to develop children's creativity. I had never studied or even fancied that creativity could be studied, let alone taught. Contemporary Chinese people inherited a long-held (more than a century) belief that their age-old Confucian tradition was the root of all their political, social, and economical ills. Confucianism was even called a culture that "ate people" by radical thinkers such as Lu Xun (1881–1936).⁵ In education, the most condemned were children lacking creativity – the sentiment holding strong to the present day. Now, to Chinese people's horror, not only did Marx's dogma and audacious experiment fail to emancipate people into freedom and creativity, but it managed to suck the last breath of human vitality out of their children. Part of my motivation to continue my graduate studies in America was to find ways to help rectify Chinese education problems (another part had to do with my lost confidence that I could ever teach in an American high school). Learning about the teachability of creativity raised hope for me again.

When I inquired where I could study creativity for a PhD, my professors recommended Harvard Graduate School of Education,⁶ where Howard Gardner was attracting many students. They gave me his book, *Frames of Mind*, to read, and reading that book made me decide that I wanted to study not just creativity but the whole human potential. I lucked out again with the admissions and began a marathon of doctoral training in human development and psychology. But my single desire to figure out human creativity and potential could not be fulfilled without also studying other important processes that influence child development. Finally and inevitably, I encountered *culture* as a developmental concept. As I delved deeper into my studies, I realized – this time, to my personal astonishment – that I had been blind to culture. I was the fish who was the last to discover water.

Once discovered, I could not see the world without water. Culture soon became the looking glass that was impossible for me to put down, even after all those years of unawareness on my part. Culture, as the largest human-created system (as opposed to our biology), penetrates so profoundly into all spheres of human life that it alters human cognition, emotion, and behavior, setting us apart from the next smartest creatures in the animal kingdom.⁷ Culture is like the air we breathe; we are completely dependent on it. Together with our biology, culture produces us, but we also alter culture

continuously. This interactive process is the inescapable force underlying child development.

For me, however, the awakening was not about human culture as a whole, but a particular culture, my own culture. Yes, what about my culture? Because I was born into a preexisting world, did my own culture imprint me in any specific way? If so, in what way? I lived my own culture as any anthropologist would attest, but why was I unaware of it for so long? Did Marxism push my culture out of me, or perhaps it buried my culture and pushed something else into me? My questions were endless, and this process was not fun. My peers from China seemed to have gone through a similarly painful process. We shared our identity crises, confusions, and reflections. One friend was already writing her dissertation and introduced me to the writings of Professor Tu Wei-ming (杜維明), an authoritative scholar on Confucianism at Harvard Yenching. I went to the Yenching Library and borrowed his books. He led me to other related books. Now, for the first time, rather late in life, I read, word for word for myself, Confucius's *Analects*, *Mencius*, and other original works. I experienced an intense process similar to when I first peeked into Western cultures through the German gate opened in college, but this time I was gazing into my own soul.

I could not believe the words and passages I was reading from these books. What we as children growing up in China were told⁸ (but not allowed to read directly) about Confucius and his ideas and the actual words by Confucius and Mencius were like day and night. I knew that if we had no reason to believe that Chinese people's intelligence is no less than that of any other people on this planet, something must have gone terribly wrong. Why did the Chinese admire Confucius for 2,500 years? Why was he called a sage and an "exemplary teacher for all ages" (萬世師表) even by the powerful (for example, emperors) and smart people (i.e. scholars), and why was his *Analects* required reading of all schoolchildren for millennia?⁹ Were all the Chinese who lived before me wrong – stupid even? These questions greatly disturbed me.

Further reading and contemplation led to the realization that the Chinese had gone through a century-long tormented soul searching because they could not defend themselves against the surging Western powers. China was in an all-around steady decline until its eventual defeat and the subsequent chaos, suffering unprecedented humiliation and loss of self-confidence. Intellectuals were the first to turn inward to self-examine, and they came to a devastating verdict: The root cause was the Confucian ideology all ruling dynasties had adopted.¹⁰ It relied on the personal moral cultivation of the

ruler to bestow mercy onto his subjects. If a ruler succeeded in cultivating himself, he attracted good and able ministers to manage his dynasty, and people enjoyed peace and prosperity as a result. But if a ruler was ruthless and tyrannical, such as the Qin Emperor who built the Great Wall but caused great suffering to people, then people revolted against the empire, sometimes successfully but oftentimes not. Whenever such a peasant uprising prevailed, another ruler arose and reinstated the same old system with the same old Confucian ideology.¹¹ Although China was blessed with some good rulers, the bad and incompetent ones outnumbered the more virtuous and able ones.

This cycle of the political process and dynastic ruling lasted for millennia, but its vitality was exhausted when Western powers pounded open China's door.¹² What defeated the Chinese system at the turn of the twentieth century, as intellectuals and politicians agreed, was really not Western troops but their science, which the Confucian ideology clearly lacked. Western science was most admired because it produced "solid ships and effective cannons" (船堅炮利), while the Chinese were still relying on spears, swords, and even martial arts to fight on land and sea. This conclusion led to a whole series of new education policies and political reform. Waves of Chinese students were sent to the West to study science and technology. Moreover, many leaders and scholars attributed Western power to their better democratic governmental systems. China, along with other East Asian nations that suffered a similar fate, began a protracted endeavor of learning from the West (a process that has not yet reached its peak), despite a period of interruption immediately after the communist takeover. I must admit that I myself was also a small element of this massive cross-cultural learning process.

CHINESE CULTURE AND FAUST AGAIN

This grasp of the general historical perspective eased my distress to some extent, but it did not persuade me that Confucius and his ideas were the root cause of, and therefore were to be blamed for, all Chinese political, social, and economic ills. Confucius lived 2,500 years ago and did not have any noted political power. He was a thinker, philosopher, and, most of all, teacher. Students came to him and sought his teaching of their own volition. It would be groundless to blame him or even his ideas for China's later problems. If anyone were to be blamed, it would be those who, under the name of Confucianism, waged unjust wars, conquered land, and established illegitimate dynasties, not to mention those who buried alive Confucian scholars

and burned their books,¹³ those who ruthlessly oppressed their people and neglected their civil duties, and those who were driven more by power and wealth than by benevolence and virtue. In other words, those who failed to achieve Confucian self-perfection but unfortunately held power. Blaming Confucius is like blaming Jesus for the medieval Inquisition and other immoral acts committed in the name of Christianity.

This new reflection made me finally realize that part of my confusion came from equating a country's political system with its culture. This confusion was the reason why, during my undergraduate years, we thought that anything Chinese was bad. But then, in graduate school, I discovered and began to feel the enormity of culture, thanks to anthropology, Confucian works, and the great body of scholarly interpretations of Ames, de Bary, Fingarette, K. K. Hwang, Ivanhoe, Munro, Rosemont, Wei-ming Tu, C. F. Yang, K. S. Yang, and Ying-shi Yu, among others. Culture is much larger and more long-lasting than any political system. Culture is even larger than the existence of society or nation: Whereas either of the latter is usually bound by a geographical location under a certain political system at a given time, the former encompasses people beyond geographical boundaries, as the case of Jewish culture demonstrates. A given society or nation can witness many political systems come and go even in a short period of time, as is the case with China.¹⁴ But people living in different systems, both successively and simultaneously, such as the Chinese living in the Mainland, Hong Kong, Singapore, Taiwan, the United States, Europe, and other parts of the world, having nothing to do with a particular political system or particular society, still unambiguously identify themselves as Chinese.

This jagged intellectual journey of mine raised the inevitable question for me: Given that I have no doubt that I am Chinese by cultural heritage, what then marks me as such a cultural member, particularly when I am no longer a citizen of Mainland China? As it turns out, this type of question is commonly asked, not just by Chinese, but by anyone who experiences cross-cultural living and the acculturation process. Although commonly asked, answers to this question are not easy to come by. Often one feels that one is different, but articulating such differences proves to be immensely challenging. In a sense, cultural psychologists and anthropologists spend their lives trying to do just that – understanding and articulating such differences among the world's peoples.

Considering the intellectual path by which I encountered two Western cultures, German and European American, it was impossible for me to ignore the topic of learning and knowing. The shadow of the Faustian Bargain still hovered over my head, and American students' indifference

toward learning still troubled me. But after I began asking the cultural question about myself, it became clear that I, not Faust or American students, was the cause of my puzzlement and problem. I grew up in a culture that has, despite the apparent political and social upheaval, a very different outlook toward learning and knowledge. That I inherited this outlook (my idiosyncratic characteristics notwithstanding) is, I dare to assert, a result of what anthropologists refer to as the process of enculturation¹⁵ rather than the storm of the Marxist swirl.

The reason, from a developmental perspective, is that the child is cared for, loved, and nurtured day to day by the caregivers. Few caregivers in Mainland Chinese families, during political turmoil or otherwise, and rarely if at all, assigned any kind of priority to delivering political messages to their children (it would be absurd). Even if parents did that, it is highly doubtful that this would have any effect during infancy and subsequent years. Based on anthropological psychology, the overarching political and economic climate is only an indirect factor that influences child development. The local cultural customs, the caregiver's psychological characteristics, and the actual daily interactions are the more direct shaping force on the child.¹⁶ This influence has its most observable effect during the formative years of infancy and early childhood, which is foundational to a person's further development. To the extent that my parents and my nannies inherited from their parents childrearing values and practices of a long-existing culture, it is likely that they adopted these deep-seated cultural frames to care for, to guide, and to discipline their child, rather than using Marxist doctrine to cook, to feed, or to love the child (to my knowledge, Marxism says nothing about human psychology, let alone childrearing routines).¹⁷

Therefore, I grew up thoroughly Chinese. For learning and education, my parents' voices will probably ring forever in my head. I recall some of their words I heard whenever they tried to encourage and instruct me and my siblings with regard to learning:

- Having studied, to then always practice what you have learned – is this not a pleasure? 學而時習之，不亦說乎？ (when we did not want to practice what we learned)
- In strolling with only two people, I am bound to find a teacher. Identifying their strengths, I follow them, and identifying their weaknesses, I correct them in myself. 三人行，必有我師焉，擇其善者而從之，其不善者而改之 (when we failed to see what we could learn from others)

- Continue studying without respite, instruct others without growing weary 學而不厭，誨人不倦 (when we grew tired of studying and of helping others in school)
- Love for learning 好學 (when we talked about going through the motions in learning)
- To know what you know and know what you do not know – this is wisdom 知之為知之，不知為不知，是知也 (when we pretended to know)
- Learn, then you will know your inadequacy 學然后知不足 (when we claimed that we knew enough)
- Do not impose on others what you yourself do not want 己所不欲勿施於人 (when we pushed things we did not like on each other)

These words turned out to be those spoken by Confucius, but I did not know that growing up. My parents began quoting with “the ancient said” (古人說) rather than “Confucius says” because they feared that announcing Confucius’s name would bring political persecution during a time when Confucius (and Confucianism) was singled out for criticism.

School learning also instilled much of these same values, norms, and preferences in me, even though schools were under greater pressure to promote Marxist ideology. Consider the following: Any Chinese classroom was, and still is, decorated with a motto “Learn well and make progress everyday” (好好學習，天天向上) – a quote by Mao Zedong. I always found it interesting that out of all of his fierce attacks of traditional education philosophy and pedagogy as expressed in his voluminous writings, this very motto was picked to be posted in every classroom to encourage student learning. Purely in its wording, the message is completely consistent with traditional Chinese learning philosophy. When I visited schools in Beijing, Nanjing, Shanghai, Shandong, Sichuan, and Guangdong during the 1990s and early 2000s, I also saw secondary and college classrooms quite uniformly decorated with these poetic verses among other similar motivational aphorisms:

Long-term diligence is the road to the mount of knowledge; endurance of hardship is the boat to the boundless sea of learning 書山有路勤為徑，學海無涯苦作舟。¹⁸

In all my school years, when we had a quiz or exam in class, the teacher frequently asked the most hardworking student, not the highest-achieving one, to stand up to receive applause from peers for his or her great learning virtue. Whenever any student did well in class, teachers would say to them,

“don’t be too proud but continue to strive to achieve better. There is no end to learning.” Whenever a student did not do well, the first line of advising and disciplining was “you did not work hard, you did not concentrate, you did not listen well in class, and you did not practice enough.” Sometimes teachers would mention that a student uses his or her mind flexibly (腦筋靈活), but I never heard any teacher, or any peer for that matter, attribute a student’s high achievement to his or her born intelligence alone; likewise, no student’s low achievement was ever attributed merely to his or her lack of inherited potential.

This unwinding of my childhood experiences has crystallized for me the intellectual tradition that holds the following notions about learning:

1. Learning is the most important thing in life; it is the life’s purpose.
2. Learning enables one to become a better, not just smarter, person. The ultimate purpose of learning is to self-perfect and to contribute to others at the same time.
3. Learning is a life-long process. It starts early in life and continues throughout one’s life.
4. The kind of knowledge that sets one person apart from another does not come to one automatically. One must seek it. Seeking knowledge requires resolve, diligence, endurance of hardship, steadfastness, concentration, and humility. One must have what the Chinese call “a heart and mind for wanting to learn” (好學心), a passion for learning.
5. Learning does not privilege anyone, and neither does it discriminate against anyone. Everyone is capable of seeking and achieving knowledge regardless of one’s inborn capacity and social circumstances.
6. One begins the learning process as a beneficiary from others’ dedicated guidance. But one will become a benefactor to others’ learning and self-cultivation as one matures, making harmony with the world.¹⁹

These ideas were (and to a large extent still are) passed down to children through the implicit as well as explicit process of enculturation. As any other cultural process, the deep-seated beliefs were learned and internalized so successfully that hardly any child questioned them and the associated values, preferences, and norms they carried.²⁰

As this returning to my own culture took place, my understanding of Western traditions also deepened. Evidently, Faust epitomizes an entirely different way of learning and knowing. Inheriting a long-standing intellectual tradition that originated from Greek antiquity through the Christian

scholarship and finally standing at the cusp of modern science, Faust (either the real person or, more likely, the combined figure created by Marlowe and Goethe) represents an approach to learning and knowing that has been essential in the Western world, and this approach still flourishes in the present day and quite possibly will continue for long. This tradition emphasizes the following key themes:

1. Human curiosity about the external world is the inspiration for knowledge.
2. Relentless spirit of inquiry into the universe will lead to knowledge.²¹
3. Mind is the highest human faculty that enables this inquiry.
4. Reason (not heart) is the process by which we know the world.
5. Learning privileges those who have superior ability.
6. The individual is the sole entity for inquiring, discovery, and ultimate triumph.

Juxtaposing these two learning traditions, the reason for the difficulties my mother, my college peers, and I had about the Faustian Bargain revealed itself: Learning and knowledge in the Confucian world are *defined* fundamentally differently. Learning and knowing are geared not to the external world, but to one's self as a goal of personal striving. Learning how to perfect oneself and to become a better person morally and socially is never viewed as a cost or liability to oneself or anyone else. As such, it is viewed not just positively, but as an ultimate good.

Apparently, my shock about American students' lack of interest in learning also stemmed from this difference in the learning outlook. My reaction may have appeared judgmental and harsh, and in hindsight was quite regrettable. American students' motivation for learning turned out to be an intricate field of study in itself, but it is no less connected to the Western intellectual tradition, as will be discussed in [Chapters 2–8](#). Still, if not anything else, my initial encounter with the students in Vermont and Pennsylvania stimulated me to look into myself, to discover my own culture, and to peek through the looking glass that has both enabled and constrained my own learning.

This arduous but eventually fruitful search finally gave birth to a research agenda. Now, after a journey on which I myself have inherited some of the Western learning spirit, I could not resist returning to the Faustian quest, but this time with much more grounding and understanding. I wanted to know if these basic learning concepts were still alive today in both cultural worlds. As a developmental researcher, my natural curiosity is directed to children. Assuming the empirical answer would be found affirmatively,

how are these beliefs transmitted to children generation after generation? Finally, how do different learning beliefs influence children's learning?

As will be seen in later chapters, I have reviewed and gathered consistent empirical support that, despite much political, social, and economical change and exchange in recent decades, the basic learning models still persist in their respective cultures. They underlie much of thinking, feeling, and behavior of learners as well as actions of their social world, and exert profound influence on their children.

NOTES

1. Quote from Knox, M. M., McGalliard, J. C., Pasinetti, P. M., Hugo, H. E., Spacks, P. M., Wellek, R., Doughlas, K., & S. Lawall (1992) *The Norton anthology of world masterpieces*, Vol. 2. New York: Norton, p. 462.
2. The New Cultural Movement (1915–1923) was a part of China's radical and painful modern history. This movement was launched by intellectuals to reform the political, economic, educational, linguistic, literary, and artistic traditions to embrace Western democratic and scientific spirit. For example, Chinese written language was forced to change from traditional grammar to vernacular grammar across all curricular materials in school. For a comprehensive discussion of the movement, see Yu, Y.-S. (1992). *中國文化與現代變遷* [Chinese culture and modern evolution]. Sanmin Publishing House.
3. Mao Zedong's reeducation program (1968–1978). In the peak of his absolute political power, Mao launched the movement, urging the so-called educated youth from middle and high school to go to the countryside to learn from the farmers. In his espoused radical theory, book knowledge was regarded as divorced from life and therefore useless for his revolution. But his theory in action, according to scholarly analyses, was a strategy to shift the burden of the large unemployment and therefore looming threat of youth unrest to the already destitute but vast farming land. Some 16 million youth were sent down, separated from their families, to work in the fields. In addition to worsening farmers' livelihood, many young people suffered social isolation, displacement, abuse, and emotional disturbances under the conditions of this vast forced-labor camp. For detailed accounts, see Meisner, M. (1999). *Mao's China and after: A history of the People's Republic* (3rd ed.). New York: Free Press; and Chang, T. H. (1999). *China during the Cultural Revolution, 1966–1976: A selected bibliography of English language works*. Westport, CT: Greenwood.
4. The first college admissions rate in 1977 after ten years of Cultural Revolution was 4.7% (27,000 admitted from 5,700,000 who took the exam. However, millions more youth from the ten years of Cultural Revolution did not take the exam. The percentage of successful students entering college that year would be much smaller if all of the potential pool were included). See SSB (State Statistics Bureau). (2005). *新中國55年統計資料匯編* [China's fifty-five years of statistical data]. Beijing, China: China Statistical Press for related statistics.

5. Lu Xun was the most forthright writer, critic of traditional Chinese culture. His novels and essays attacked Confucianism most vehemently. See reference in Note 2 to this chapter for a historical discussion and reevaluation of the anti-tradition writers and other intellectuals in early-twentieth-century China.
6. Finally, I have a chance to express my much belated gratitude to Professors Mushalko and Fredette at the University of Pittsburgh for opening my mind to creativity in children and for mentioning Harvard Graduate School of Education to me. I had no clue that I might not have been qualified to apply. I am forever indebted for their encouragement and confidence.
7. See Tomasello, M. (1999). *The cultural origins of human cognition*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press for his research on the topic of how human culture as a whole has been part of our heritage and how human cognition and social understanding are irreversibly altered.
8. During my formative years, we read nothing by Confucian scholars. But because Mao Zedong liked some writing by Xun Zi (Hsun Tzu 荀子, 325–235 BCE), strangely, the centralized textbook for middle school children during the 1970s contained one of Xun Zi's most famous essay "Advice on Learning" (勸學篇), which we were required to memorize. Xun Zi was, with Confucius and Mencius, one of the three early Confucians. However, other than this serendipity, schoolchildren were told that Confucius and his followers were counterrevolutionaries; they disregarded working people; they only valued book knowledge and preached ideas for the ruling class. This vicious distortion and Machiavellian attack of Confucius was the reason why many of my generation felt cheated and lied to about our own culture. These lies become apparent when one opens the *Analects* and *Mencius* and reads for oneself. What a change we witnessed when the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games opened with the second line in Confucius *Analects* "To have friends [who share the goal of self-cultivation] come from distant quarters – is this not enjoyment?" (translated in watered-down English as "Welcome my friends") in front of the 1.3 billion Chinese not just in Mainland China but all Chinese in the world! What a sharp contrast it is for the current Chinese leadership to revamp the fundamental Confucian value of harmony and elevate it to a national agenda for building a harmonious society (although no leader has openly acknowledged its Confucian origin)! All this is signaling to me a cultural awakening, as far as Confucianism is concerned, despite the fast process of Westernization and globalization.
9. *Analects* was a required reading of all schoolchildren since the Han Dynasty (206 BCE–22 CE) until the early twentieth century when the Civil Service Examination system was abolished. But the *Fours Books* and the *Five Scriptures* continued to be taught as the basic texts to schoolchildren until the communists took power in 1945. However, Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Singapore continued (many schools to date still) to require such Confucian books in school; see a review by C.-L. Yang (1995). 論兒童讀經的淵源及從理想層面探討兩種讀經法的功能 [Reciting or listening to the origin and ideal of children's classics training]. 高雄國文學報 [Bulletin of Chinese] (National Kaohsiung Normal University), 8, 1–50. As such, my mother at age nine in 1930 began her schooling by formally acknowledging Confucius as the "teacher for all ages" and her own private tutor and by

being taught Confucius' *Analects* first. She could still recite much of it well into her late 80s. Likewise, my father at age ten in the 1920s began his schooling with Confucian *Analects* in a village private tutoring school (私塾).

10. See the paragraph on the Civil Service Examination system in the section *Taking the World Upon Oneself* in Chapter 2.
11. See X.-R. Han (2006). *Chinese discourses on the peasant, 1900–1949*. Albany, NY: State University of New York Press; and Gernet, J., Foster, J. R., & Hartman, C. (1996). *A history of Chinese civilization*. New York: Cambridge University Press, for reviews of the dynastic cycle in Chinese history.
12. Western powers opened the door to China. The Opium War and events that followed led to Dr. Sun Yat-sen's revolution in 1911, ending the millennia-long dynastic ruling system in China. The subsequent period was governed by the Nationalist government until the Communist takeover in 1945.
13. Emperor Qin (259–210 BCE) murdered Confucian scholars by burying them alive and by burning their books (213–212 BCE).
14. China for the last century went through dynasty to semi-colony, republic, warlord rule, communist, planned economy, and now market economy. The notion of culture outlasts all of these short-lived governmental forms.
15. See LeVine, R. A. (1990). Enculturation: A biosocial perspective on the development of self. In D. Cicchetti & M. Beeghly (Eds.), *The self in transition: Infancy to childhood* (pp. 99–117). Chicago: University of Chicago Press on the notion of enculturation.
16. See Harkness, S., & Super, C. (1992). The developmental niche: A theoretical framework for analyzing the household production of health. *Social science and Medicine*, 38, 217–226 for their introduction to the notion of “developmental niche.” See Trevarthen, C. (1998). The concept and foundation of infant intersubjectivity. In S. Braten (Ed.), *Intersubject communication and emotion in early ontogeny* (pp. 15–46). New York: Cambridge University Press for a review of research on infant-caregiver intersubjectivity.
17. This section was not frivolously written but intended to respond to those who falsely assumed that because the Mainland Chinese lived under a particular political system, somehow they were not normal, worse yet that their parental love and care somehow were subquality, and worse, because they did not receive any cultural heritage.
18. There is little wonder why this set of verses entered the top-twenty list of my learning lexicon study (see more details of the research in Chapter 3).
19. That learning and acquisition of culturally desirable skills also brings practical benefits such as getting a job or supporting oneself or one's family is not a unique Chinese value. It is common value for all humans. Naturally, Chinese people also learn for practical purposes. Chapters 2 and 3 discuss how this part is integrated with the higher purposes of Confucian learning tradition.
20. Yes, Emperor Qin buried Confucian scholars alive and burned their books, and there were other times of persecution of learning, including censored learning in recent history. But these events only proved the Emperor's cruelty and the subsequent times' inhumanity, which faces continuous condemnation. This side of the history, particularly Emperor Qin's tyranny, remains a permanent blemish on Chinese conscience. The learned were and still are the cultural heroes.

Intellectuals during the New Cultural Movement and in a more distorted form throughout recent Chinese history also questioned, attacked, and rejected this learning tradition. However, as will be seen in later chapters, this tradition is not easily done away with. Its power and tenacity are yet to be understood. The fact that only one slogan, “Learn well and make progress everyday,” from Mao’s voluminous writings got posted in *every* classroom (but no other quote from him enjoyed this persistent popularity) is testimony to the tenacity of this learning tradition. Whenever children see this quote, no specific context in which Mao uttered those words accompanied the sight; nor did any teacher bother to qualify to children that the quote was only for communist purpose. The quote hangs above the blackboard, viewable without failure by anyone entering the classroom. It hangs there, decontextualized forever, as if it is a stand-alone and eternal halo. It is so powerful and enduring that it continues to be the sight in every classroom today. All I had ever heard in China for my twenty-five years of school presence was study hard to contribute to society. Therefore, what message children and teachers receive is the bare meaning of these words, which, as already noted, is but consistent with the enduring Confucian learning tradition. Children study hard regardless of the political system. In a strange way, the very political force that thought itself iconoclastic against tradition ended up promoting and perpetuating the tradition. To me – but to no surprise of any anthropologist – this is but a common manifestation of the enduring power of culture. Viewed from this perspective, this learning tradition transcends time and space and therefore any political system. The claim of this learning tradition meets ample empirical support in and outside China wherever Chinese flourish in the world.

21. However the universe was defined. Faust got himself in trouble because the universe was conceived of, at his time, as God’s will and design that was not fully knowable by humans; humans were forbidden from pursuing such knowledge. Although modern philosophy and science no longer treat divinity as the ontological giving of the world, and modern Fausts do not have to give up their lives for their quest, the questions of how the external world is knowable or how certainly it is knowable to humans continue to generate epistemological debates in these fields.